

buy anything. Part of me felt bamboozled into this new lifestyle, and at times I found myself annoyed by the lack of space. But I enjoyed the RV and knew that in order to love the lifestyle, I needed to find contentment with the things I already had and new activities to replace what I previously thought was important to me.

In a world that thrives on discontent, finding contentment is radical. Contentment in its purest form is to feel satisfied with one's possessions, status, or situation. If simplifying and community building are what curates our external environment to create sustainability in our values-based lifestyle, then contentment is how we curate our internal environment (i.e., our mindset). Without contentment, we are susceptible to both the internal and external forces driving us to spend money to solve our problems. With contentment, many of those problems don't exist.

I used to think of the embodiment of contentment as an unhurried elderly woman in her garden. Moving through the shrubs, flowers, vines, and trees planted by her over decades. Taking time to visit each one and tenderly caring, pruning, plucking, admiring. Enjoying the fresh air and giving herself time to close her eyes in the sun.

In reality, there's no way this woman actually exists. Not because there aren't lots of older women in their gardens, but because a person content at all times is impossible to come by. We will never arrive at a place and stay there forever, either literally or metaphorically. Humans are designed to crave, grow, and improve. But we *can* experience peace inside ourselves related to our perceptions of our stuff, our status, and our situation more often than not. Which will ultimately lead to better spending.

The key here is how we choose to *view* our circumstances.

I find it interesting that every aspect of contentment's definition—possession, status, and situation—intersects with our engagement with money. It says nothing about how abundant or luxurious any of the categories are, simply how one “feels” or “shows” satisfaction toward them. Mmm! I could end it there and let us all go ponder that one. But we'll stick together and chat about some of the ways we can experience contentment throughout life and what this means for our money.

Naturally, we can't just talk about contentment without exploring the extremes we could find ourselves in on its spectrum. If contentment is the radical middle, then hustle culture and complacency are on either side. And along the entire spectrum, we can find discontentment. It can crop up as